

Adam Smith's Theory of Moral Sentiments

Sympathy, the Impartial Spectator, and the Unity of Smith's Science of Human Nature

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1 Introduction: A Science of Moral Judgement

Adam Smith (1723–1790) is remembered first as the author of the *Wealth of Nations* and the founding figure of political economy, but he was by training and by self-conception a moral philosopher. He held the Chair of Moral Philosophy at Glasgow, where he had himself been the pupil of Francis Hutcheson and where he became the close friend of David Hume; and the work he revised most lovingly across his whole life was not the *Wealth of Nations* but *The Theory of Moral Sentiments*, first published in 1759 and reissued, with substantial additions, through a sixth edition that appeared in the year of his death. The two books are best understood as two parts of a single, larger project: a comprehensive science of human nature and society, of which moral philosophy and political economy are branches, with a projected third branch on law and government that Smith never completed.

The aim of *The Theory of Moral Sentiments* is not to legislate a moral code but to *explain* moral judgement – to give a naturalistic account of how creatures like us come to approve and disapprove, to feel obligation, to praise and blame, others and ourselves. Smith's answer is resolutely intersubjective. Morality, for him, is not read off from a divine command, nor deduced from reason alone, nor reducible to a single master-feeling such as benevolence. It is *constructed* out of the interplay between agents and observers through the mechanism of *sympathy*, and progressively refined under a regulative ideal that Smith makes the centrepiece of the whole system: the *impartial spectator*. The book proceeds by building moral life up in layers, each layer explained by the same spectatorial mechanism applied to a new object – first the propriety of others' conduct, then the desert of actions, then the judgement of oneself, and finally the general rules and settled virtues that stabilise the whole.

The spectatorial construction: a moral phenomenon built up through sympathy and the impartial spectator

The recurring move. Smith takes a feature of moral experience to be explained – approval, desert, conscience, duty – and accounts for it through the same apparatus. We cannot feel another's sentiments directly; by *imagination* we place ourselves in the other's situation and generate an analogous sentiment of our own. Moral approval

is then the *concord* between the sentiment we so generate as spectators and the sentiment actually felt by the person concerned. As the procedure is turned outward (on others), reciprocally (on the desert of actions), and finally inward (on ourselves, through the figure of the impartial spectator), it yields in turn the standards of propriety, of merit, of conscience, and of general rules – so that the entire edifice of morality is erected from sympathy disciplined by spectatorship, with no faculty smuggled in from outside.

This method gives Smith his distinctive position among eighteenth-century moralists. Against the rationalists, he holds that moral distinctions are founded ultimately on sentiment, not on reason alone. Against his teacher Hutcheson, he denies that there is a special “moral sense” or that virtue reduces to benevolence. Against Hume, with whom he agrees on much, he reconceives sympathy and insists that approval tracks the *propriety* of sentiments and not merely their *utility*. And against Mandeville, whose claim that private vices are public benefits Smith regarded as a dangerous half-truth, he insists that genuine virtue is real and not a disguised form of vanity. The chapters that follow set out the construction in order.

2 Sympathy: The Foundational Mechanism

Everything begins with *sympathy*, and Smith’s first task is to correct a likely misunderstanding of the word. Sympathy, in his usage, is not pity or compassion narrowly, nor is it benevolence. It is the general human capacity to enter into and share the feelings of others, whatever those feelings may be – joy as much as sorrow, indignation as much as grief. The famous opening sentence states the datum the book will explain: however selfish a person may be supposed, there are plainly principles in his nature that interest him in the fortunes of others and make their happiness necessary to him, though he derives nothing from it but the pleasure of seeing it.

The mechanism is the crucial point, and it is what distinguishes Smith’s sympathy from Hume’s. We have, Smith insists, no immediate experience of what other people feel; their sensations are forever beyond our direct reach. We form an idea of their feelings only by *imagining ourselves in their situation* – by representing to ourselves what we should feel were we in their circumstances – and this act of imaginative projection generates in us an emotion analogous to theirs. Sympathy is thus not emotional contagion, not the mechanical transmission of a feeling from one breast to another. It is an imaginative reconstruction of the other’s situation that produces a parallel sentiment in the spectator. This has an important consequence that Smith exploits throughout: because sympathy works through the *situation* and its exciting causes, we can sympathise with passions

we judge appropriate to a situation even when the person concerned does not feel them, and we can withhold sympathy from passions we judge inappropriate even when they are intensely felt. Sympathy is responsive to the fittingness of a passion to its cause, not merely to its presence and intensity.

To this Smith adds a second principle that drives the entire dynamic of the moral life: human beings take a distinctive *pleasure in mutual sympathy*, in the discovery that others share their sentiments, and a corresponding discomfort when their feelings find no echo. Nothing pleases us more than to observe in others a fellow-feeling with the emotions of our own breast, and nothing hurts us more than the appearance of the contrary. This craving for concord is not, Smith argues, reducible to self-interest; it is a basic fact of our sociable nature, and it is the engine that pushes agents and spectators toward one another until their sentiments can meet.

3 Propriety and the Spectator

From sympathy Smith derives his first and most basic category of moral assessment: *propriety*. To judge whether another person's passion is suitable – proper, fitting – is simply to ask whether we, surveying their situation as spectators, can *go along with* it. If, on imagining ourselves in their circumstances, the sympathetic emotion we generate matches in kind and degree the emotion they actually display, we approve: their passion is proper, and our approval just is our felt concord with it. If our sympathetic emotion falls short of theirs – if they grieve or rage far more than we, entering into their situation, find ourselves able to grieve or rage – we disapprove the excess as improper. Approval and disapproval are, at bottom, the harmony or dissonance between the sentiments of the agent and the sympathetic sentiments of the observer. Moral assessment is in this way irreducibly relational: there is no propriety in a passion considered in isolation, only propriety relative to what an observer can share – a standard that Smith ultimately refines into the verdict of a properly informed and impartial spectator, not the reaction of any actual bystander.

Because mutual sympathy is pleasant and dissonance painful, this judgement sets up a double movement of accommodation that is among Smith's most original psychological observations. On the one side, the spectator strains to enter as fully as possible into the situation of the person principally concerned, exerting imagination to feel with them. On the other side – and this is the more consequential effort – the person principally concerned, longing for the relief of sympathy and knowing that the spectator cannot match the full pitch of a private passion, *lowers* the tone of their emotion to the level at which the spectator can accompany them. The sufferer composes their grief; the angry man moderates his fury to what bystanders can endorse; each “flattens,” in Smith's image,

the sharpness of their feeling to a “concord pitch” the spectator can reach. This lowering of one’s own passion to the point of shareable concord is the very root of *self-command*, the discipline by which the agent masters feeling for the sake of fellowship.

From the two efforts Smith draws his elegant distinction between two families of virtue. The spectator’s effort to feel *with* the afflicted gives rise to the soft, gentle, *amiable* virtues – sensibility, humanity, compassionate fellow-feeling. The agent’s effort to *rein in* their own passion to what others can share gives rise to the great, awful, *respectable* virtues – the self-denial, the self-government, the command of the passions that earns admiration. Virtue lies, for Smith as for the Stoics he admired, not in the extinction of passion but in its government: in feeling to the degree, and in the manner, that an observer can approve.

The spectatorial construction: a moral phenomenon built up through sympathy and the impartial spectator

Phenomenon: approval of another’s conduct (propriety). *Mechanism*: imaginative sympathy with the agent’s situation, and the concord – or dissonance – between the spectator’s sympathetic sentiment and the agent’s actual sentiment. *Result*: the standard of propriety, plus a reciprocal accommodation in which the agent lowers their passion to a shareable pitch – the origin of self-command and of the division between the amiable virtues (the spectator’s fellow-feeling) and the respectable virtues (the agent’s self-government).

4 Merit and Demerit

Propriety concerns the *affections* from which an action springs – whether the motive is suitable to its object. But morality also assesses actions as deserving *reward* or *punishment*, as having *merit* or *demerit*, and this requires Smith to compound his mechanism. To judge desert, the spectator does not sympathise with one party only but with two at once. There is a *direct* sympathy with the affections and motives of the agent who acts, and an *indirect* sympathy with the sentiments of the person who is acted upon – with the gratitude of the one who is benefited, or with the resentment of the one who is harmed.

Merit, on this analysis, is the quality of an action that renders it a proper object of *gratitude*: we judge an action meritorious, deserving of reward, when we can enter both into the agent’s beneficent motive and into the gratitude of the person who has received the benefit, so that we go along with the impulse to return good for good. Demerit is the mirror image: an action is blameworthy and deserving of punishment when we sympathise with the agent’s improper motive in reverse – that is, when we share the *resentment* of the person injured, and go along with their impulse to retaliate. Desert is thus a compound sentiment, built from a sympathy with the agent and a sympathy with

the patient acting in concert.

This account has a far-reaching corollary, for it grounds *justice* in the propriety of resentment. Punishment is justified, in Smith's eyes, precisely insofar as an impartial spectator would share the victim's resentment and approve its being acted upon. Resentment – a passion that a more refined morality is often tempted to disown – is for Smith a necessary guardian of justice, the natural sentiment by which violations of right are registered and answered, and the moral legitimacy of punishment is measured by how far a disinterested observer can enter into it. The negative, defensive character of justice, examined further below, follows from this sentimental root.

The spectatorial construction: a moral phenomenon built up through sympathy and the impartial spectator

Phenomenon: the desert of actions – their fitness for reward or punishment (merit and demerit). *Mechanism*: a compounded sympathy, direct with the agent's motive and indirect with the gratitude of the benefited or the resentment of the injured. *Result*: merit as the proper object of gratitude and demerit as the proper object of resentment, with the propriety of resentment serving as the sentimental foundation of justice and punishment.

5 The Impartial Spectator and Conscience

So far the mechanism has been turned outward, on the conduct of others. Smith's decisive and most original step is to turn it *inward*, upon ourselves – and to show that self-judgement is only possible by a kind of internal doubling. We cannot examine our own sentiments and conduct from no standpoint at all; we can do it only by viewing ourselves as we imagine *another* would view us. In examining my own conduct, Smith says, I divide myself, as it were, into two persons: the *I* who is the examiner and judge, and the *I* who is examined and judged. The judging self adopts the position of a spectator and asks how my conduct would appear to one who looked on it with the eyes of a disinterested observer, neither flattering me with the partiality of self-love nor injuring me with hostility.

The impartial spectator

The figure Smith calls "the man within the breast," "the inmate of the breast," the "supposed impartial and well-informed spectator," is the internalised standpoint of a disinterested observer who is fully informed of our situation and motives but invested with none of our self-partiality. Conscience, for Smith, is not a special faculty or an innate moral sense but precisely this: the habit of judging our own conduct as such

a spectator would. It is built up from our experience of judging others and of being judged by them, and then carried within as a permanent inner tribunal. Its authority lies in its impartiality – it sees our case as one case among others, stripped of the distortions that the love of self introduces.

The impartial spectator allows Smith to draw a distinction that lies at the moral heart of the book: the distinction between the desire for *praise* and the desire for *praiseworthiness*. The unreflective man wants to be praised. But the morally developed person comes to want something more and different – to be *worthy* of praise, to deserve approval whether or not it is actually bestowed, and conversely to dread being *blameworthy* even when no one blames him and his fault is concealed from the world. The love of praiseworthiness is the love of being the proper object of the impartial spectator's approval; and because that spectator is internal, his verdict can stand against the verdict of the actual world. A person unjustly condemned by everyone around him may yet be sustained by the approval of the man within the breast; a person flattered by all may yet be tormented by that inner judge's disapproval. Here Smith's naturalistic, intersubjective ethics acquires a principle of moral independence: the internalised spectator, though originally derived from the opinions of others, comes to be capable of correcting and resisting them.

Smith is careful, however, not to make the inner tribunal infallible or wholly autonomous. The man within the breast is in part formed by, and can be partly overawed by, the man without – the clamour of actual society. In moments of factional passion or universal misjudgement, the inner spectator's voice may be drowned out, and Smith acknowledges that in the most extreme cases the appeal must be made to a still higher and more perfectly impartial tribunal, that of a well-informed and all-seeing judge. But the central thought is firmly this-worldly: conscience is the impartial spectator carried within, and moral self-government is the practice of consulting and obeying him.

The spectatorial construction: a moral phenomenon built up through sympathy and the impartial spectator

Phenomenon: the judgement of one's own conduct, and conscience. *Mechanism:* the splitting of the self into examiner and examined, with the examiner adopting the standpoint of an impartial, well-informed spectator. *Result:* conscience as the man within the breast, and the elevation of the desire for praiseworthiness above the desire for praise – giving the moral agent a standard capable of standing against actual public opinion.

6 General Rules, Duty, Justice, and Beneficence

Particular judgements of the impartial spectator, repeated across many cases, settle over time into *general rules* of conduct. By observing again and again which actions the impartial spectator approves and which he condemns, we form to ourselves general maxims – that such-and-such kinds of action are to be done, and such-and-such avoided. These rules are indispensable, for they correct the distortions that self-love and the passion of the moment continually introduce into our particular judgements. In the heat of desire or anger, the impartial spectator’s voice is faint and easily silenced; the remembered authority of a general rule, fixed in calmer moments, holds the agent to a standard that present passion would otherwise overturn. A regard to such general rules is what Smith calls the *sense of duty*, and it is the principal security of right conduct for the great mass of humankind, who could not be trusted to judge each case afresh.

The general rules are not all of a piece, however, and Smith insists on a sharp distinction in their character – the distinction between the rules of *justice* and those of *beneficence*. It is one of the most consequential distinctions in the book and a direct bridge to his political economy.

Justice and beneficence

Justice is a “negative” virtue: in the main it consists in *refraining* from injuring others – their person, property, and rights. Its rules are precise, determinate, and accurate, admitting of little or no exception, and capable of being stated almost like the rules of grammar. Because the failure to observe them is a positive harm that provokes the resentment of the injured and the disapproval of every spectator, justice may rightly be *extorted by force*; it can be compelled. Smith’s image is architectural: justice is the main pillar that upholds the whole edifice of society, and were it removed the great fabric of human society would crumble into atoms. *Beneficence*, by contrast, is the free doing of positive good – generosity, gratitude, friendship, charity. Its rules are loose, vague, and indeterminate; it is the ornament that embellishes the building rather than the foundation that supports it. It cannot be extorted by force, and its absence, while it may disappoint, does no positive wrong that warrants punishment. Society can subsist, though in a less agreeable state, without beneficence; it cannot subsist amid the mutual injury that the absence of justice would unleash.

This asymmetry matters enormously for what follows. Justice – the enforceable framework of rules against harm and the protection of property and contract – is the precondition of all social life, including economic life. It is precise enough to be codified into law and backed by the magistrate’s force. Beneficence is more amiable and loveable in one sense, but justice is more necessary; and beneficence is precisely *not* the cement of

large-scale society among strangers, because it cannot be relied upon or compelled. A great society of people who are largely unknown to one another can be held together by justice without being held together by love; and that possibility is exactly what the *Wealth of Nations* will take for granted.

The spectatorial construction: a moral phenomenon built up through sympathy and the impartial spectator

Phenomenon: the bindingness of duty and the distinctive force of justice. *Mechanism:* the generalisation of the impartial spectator's particular verdicts into standing rules, which correct the partiality of self-love. *Result:* the sense of duty as regard to general rules, and a sharp division between justice – negative, precise, enforceable, the load-bearing pillar of society – and beneficence, the free and unenforceable ornament.

7 The Virtues and Self-Command

Smith's account of the particular virtues organises them around the spectatorial framework and shows the influence of his Stoic models, tempered by his own more sociable temperament. Four cardinal virtues structure the discussion. *Prudence* is the proper and reasonable care of one's own health, fortune, rank, and reputation – the well-regulated pursuit of one's own interest. Smith treats prudence not as a vice or a moral neutrality but as a genuine, if cooler, virtue: the impartial spectator approves the man who looks soberly to his own concerns, provided he does so within the bounds of justice. This favourable verdict on enlightened self-regard is worth marking, since it is often forgotten by those who suppose that the morality of the *Theory of Moral Sentiments* is built on benevolence alone. *Justice* and *beneficence*, already examined, are the two other-regarding virtues, the one negative and enforceable, the other positive and free.

Presiding over all of them stands *self-command*, the virtue Smith places at the summit. From self-command all the other virtues derive much of their lustre, for it is the mastery of fear, anger, and desire – the lowering of the passions to the pitch the impartial spectator can approve – that makes propriety, justice, and even prudence possible in the face of temptation. Here Smith is at his most Stoic: he learned from the Stoics that virtue is a matter of the government rather than the eradication of feeling, that the wise person views his own concerns from the standpoint of an impartial observer of the universe, and that self-command is the crown of character. Yet Smith parts company with Stoic severity. He rejects the Stoic ideal of *apatheia*, the extinction of the passions and the indifference to external goods; the natural affections – love of family, of friends, of country – are for Smith not weaknesses to be overcome but the proper material of a virtuous life, and a sympathy too thoroughly mastered would be a coldness, not a perfection. The amiable

virtues of tenderness and humanity must temper the awful virtues of self-denial. Smith's ideal is a person who feels strongly and governs well, not one who has ceased to feel.

8 Nature, the Invisible Hand, and the Corruption of Moral Sentiments

Running beneath Smith's psychology is a teleological view of nature that he shares with much of the optimistic strand of eighteenth-century thought, though he handles it with notable irony. The sentiments by which we judge and act, Smith repeatedly suggests, have been so contrived by nature as to promote the good and the preservation of the species, often by means that the individual agent neither intends nor understands. The most striking case is his treatment of the pursuit of wealth and greatness, and it is here that the *Theory of Moral Sentiments* contains the first of Smith's two famous uses of the phrase *invisible hand* in his major published books.

The rich, Smith observes, pursue the gratification of their own vain and insatiable desires; they consume little more than the poor in the way of necessities, for the capacity of the stomach is limited, and the surplus of their vast estates is distributed, through the employment they provide and the luxury they purchase, to the many who labour for them. Thus the proud and unfeeling landlord, attending only to his own greatness, is "led by an invisible hand" to make nearly the same distribution of the necessities of life that would have obtained had the earth been divided equally among all its inhabitants, and so without intending it advances the interest of society. This is the moral-philosophical ancestor of the more celebrated invisible hand of the *Wealth of Nations*: an unintended public benefit produced by the self-regarding conduct of individuals, presented as evidence of the providential design of nature.

But Smith is no naive celebrant of acquisitiveness, and the same Part of the book contains his sober analysis of what he calls the *deception of nature*. The poor man's son, visited by ambition, imagines that wealth and rank will bring contentment; he toils and schemes through a wretched life to obtain "trinkets of frivolous utility," conveniences that, weighed honestly, scarcely repay the tranquillity they cost. The pursuit of riches and greatness is, in the calm hours of reflection, largely an illusion about the sources of happiness. And yet, Smith says, it is *well* that nature deceives us in this way, for this very deception "rouses and keeps in continual motion the industry of mankind"; it is what drives men to build, cultivate, invent, and found cities and commonwealths. The economic dynamism that Smith will later anatomise rests, on this account, on a kind of benign illusion about what wealth can do for us.

This ambivalence sharpens into outright criticism in one of the most pointed passages

of the book, and it is the passage that most directly complicates any simple harmony between Smith's two great works. The disposition to admire, and almost to worship, the rich and the powerful, and to despise or neglect persons of poor and mean condition, is, Smith declares, the great and most universal cause of the *corruption of our moral sentiments*. Because the world tends to bestow its sympathy and approval on the prosperous and to withhold it from the obscure, the love of praiseworthiness is constantly in danger of degenerating into the love of mere wealth and station, and the path of virtue and the path of fortune, which ought to coincide, fall apart. The very engine that drives a commercial society – the universal striving after wealth and the deference paid to those who possess it – is, in Smith's moral diagnosis, also a standing source of moral corruption. This is the critical thread that any account of the relation between the two books must take seriously.

The spectatorial construction: a moral phenomenon built up through sympathy and the impartial spectator

Phenomenon: the social usefulness, and the moral hazard, of the pursuit of wealth. *Mechanism:* what Smith often presents, sometimes with irony, as nature's design works through unintended consequences – the self-regarding rich are led "by an invisible hand" to benefit the many, and a benign deception about the value of riches keeps industry in motion. *Result:* an account that both anticipates the economics of the *Wealth of Nations* and warns, in the same breath, that admiration of wealth corrupts the moral sentiments – ambivalence, not unqualified endorsement.

9 Smith Among the Moralists

Before turning to the relation between Smith's two books, his place among rival moral theories deserves a brief notice, since the final Part of the *Theory of Moral Sentiments* is devoted to surveying them and locating his own. Smith treats the central question of ethics as twofold: wherein does virtue consist, and by what power of the mind is it recommended to us? Against Hutcheson, who answered the first question with benevolence and the second with a special moral sense, Smith argues that virtue is not a single quality but a propriety distributed across the affections, and that no dedicated moral sense need be postulated, since approval is explained by sympathy. Against the systems that make *utility* the foundation – a tendency he associates with Hume – Smith allows that the usefulness of qualities does contribute to our approval of them, but denies that it is the original or the principal ground; we approve the propriety of sentiments directly, and the perception of utility is a later and secondary consideration. Against Mandeville's "licentious" system, which resolves all apparent virtue into refined self-love and vanity, Smith mounts a sustained rebuttal, conceding that vanity and the desire for approval are

powerful but insisting that the love of true praiseworthiness is a distinct and irreducible principle, so that virtue is not, as Mandeville would have it, a fraud. And from the Stoics he takes more than from anyone – the centrality of self-command and propriety, the standpoint of the impartial observer – while rejecting their extinction of the passions. The resulting position is a sentimentalism that is neither reductively benevolent nor reductively utilitarian: a theory of morals as the disciplined, intersubjective refinement of natural feeling.

10 One Story or Two? The Theory of Moral Sentiments and the Wealth of Nations

The question that has shadowed Smith’s reputation since the nineteenth century is whether his two masterworks tell one coherent story or two contradictory ones. *The Theory of Moral Sentiments* appears to ground social life in *sympathy* – in our capacity to feel with others; the *Wealth of Nations* appears to ground economic life in *self-interest* – in the butcher, the brewer, and the baker who provide our dinner not from benevolence but from regard to their own advantage. A tradition of mostly German nineteenth-century scholarship made this apparent opposition into a thesis, christened *Das Adam Smith Problem*: the charge that the author of the sympathy-based ethics of 1759 had, by 1776, become the theorist of a self-interested commercial order, and that the two works rest on incompatible accounts of human motivation.

Das Adam Smith Problem

The classic formulation holds that the *Theory of Moral Sentiments* explains conduct by sympathy and other-regarding sentiment, while the *Wealth of Nations* explains conduct by self-love, and that the two are inconsistent – as though Smith had changed his view of human nature, or compartmentalised it incoherently. The modern scholarly consensus, articulated authoritatively by the editors of the standard Glasgow Edition (D. D. Raphael and A. L. Macfie) and now widely shared, is that the problem rests on a misreading of both books and dissolves once that misreading is corrected. The two works are complementary parts of a single science of human nature, not rival theories of motivation.

Several considerations dismantle the alleged contradiction.

First, the *Theory of Moral Sentiments* does not condemn self-interest, and the *Wealth of Nations* does not celebrate selfishness. As shown above, Smith makes *prudence* – the well-regulated care of one’s own interest – a genuine virtue, and he holds explicitly that every person is, by nature, first and principally committed to his own care. The morality

of the first book never demanded that conduct be motivated by benevolence; it demanded that conduct, whatever its motive, meet the standard of propriety set by the impartial spectator. Self-interested action that stays within the rules of justice is, for the Smith of 1759, perfectly proper. The self-love of the butcher and the baker is therefore not a betrayal of the *Theory of Moral Sentiments* but an instance of exactly the prudence it had already approved.

Second, the self-interest of the *Wealth of Nations* operates *within* the moral and legal framework that the *Theory of Moral Sentiments* describes, and presupposes it. The market is not a war of all against all; it is exchange conducted among people bound by the enforceable rules of justice – the precise, negative rules against harm, theft, and breach of contract that the earlier book had singled out as the load-bearing pillar of society. Smith’s commercial actors pursue their advantage by *persuasion and exchange*, by offering others what those others want, not by force or fraud; the famous appeal to the self-love of the tradesman is an appeal to give him what he wants in return for what we want, which is the civil and rule-governed face of self-interest, not its rapacious one. The economics of the second book is unintelligible without the jurisprudence and the moral psychology of the first.

Third, the chronology refutes the developmental version of the charge decisively. Smith did not write the *Theory of Moral Sentiments* in his sympathetic youth and the *Wealth of Nations* in his disenchanted maturity and then leave the first behind. He revised the *Theory of Moral Sentiments* most heavily *after* the *Wealth of Nations* had appeared, producing its substantially enlarged sixth edition in 1790, fourteen years later – and far from retracting or softening its moral psychology, he deepened it, adding, among other things, the sharpened analysis of how the admiration of wealth corrupts the moral sentiments. Had he perceived a contradiction between his two books, he had every opportunity and every motive to repair it; instead he reaffirmed and strengthened the ethics. Moreover, Smith himself announced the unity of the project: the closing paragraph of the *Theory of Moral Sentiments* promises a further work on the general principles of law and government, and the advertisement to the sixth edition notes that he had in part discharged that promise in the *Wealth of Nations*. The two books were, by their author’s own testimony, branches of one system.

Fourth, and most deeply, the same intellectual signature governs both works: the explanation of *unintended order* arising from individual conduct. In the *Theory of Moral Sentiments*, a stable moral order – shared standards of propriety, merit, and justice – emerges from the countless local interactions of agents and spectators seeking mutual sympathy, with no one designing the result. In the *Wealth of Nations*, a productive economic order – the coordination of supply with demand, the allocation of labour and capital – emerges from the countless local exchanges of self-interested traders, with no

one designing the result. The very figure of the invisible hand appears in both. Smith's master idea, across ethics and economics alike, is that large-scale social order is a spontaneous, unintended outcome of dispersed individual action governed by general rules, not the deliberate construction of any planner. On this reading the two books are not merely compatible; they are two applications of a single, characteristic vision.

It would be too tidy, however, to declare a seamless harmony and stop there, for there are real tensions in Smith's outlook that the dissolution of the formal "problem" should not be allowed to conceal. They are tensions *within* his vision of commercial society rather than contradictions *between* his books, but they are genuine, and Smith was the first to register them.

The first is the corruption already noted. The *Theory of Moral Sentiments* warns that the disposition to admire the rich and despise the poor is the great and most universal cause of moral corruption – and the *Wealth of Nations* describes a society organised around precisely the accumulation and display of wealth. Smith is thus, in the same body of work, both the analyst and, in a measured way, the critic of commercial striving: he sees that the engine of prosperity is also a solvent of virtue, and he does not pretend the two effects cancel.

The second tension arises within the *Wealth of Nations* itself, in Smith's analysis of the *division of labour*. The minute subdivision of tasks that is the source of commercial productivity has, he observes, a debasing effect on the worker whose whole life is confined to a few simple operations: such a person loses the habit of exertion and invention and becomes, in Smith's unsparing phrase, as stupid and ignorant as it is possible for a human creature to become, his mind mutilated by the very efficiency that enriches the nation. This is not the complaint of an outside critic; it is Smith's own, and it expresses, from inside his economics, the same concern for the full development of moral character that animates his ethics. He recommends public education partly as a remedy, precisely because he will not let the wealth of the nation be purchased at the cost of the degradation of its people.

The mature verdict, then, is this. The two works do not conflict; the *Adam Smith Problem*, taken as a charge of inconsistency, is a pseudo-problem founded on caricaturing the role of sympathy in the one book and of self-interest in the other. They are complementary parts of a single science of human nature and society, unified by a common method and an explicit authorial intention. But complementarity is not the same as untroubled optimism. Smith's overall vision of commercial society is ambivalent rather than celebratory: he holds that the pursuit of wealth, governed by justice, produces both prosperity and a great unintended social order, and at the same time that it endangers virtue and can mutilate the human beings whose labour sustains it. The unity of Smith's thought lies

not in a bland concord between sympathy and self-interest, but in a single, clear-eyed account of how a society of self-regarding individuals, bound by the rules of justice and watched over by the impartial spectator, can be at once productive, orderly, and morally imperilled.

11 Modern Criticism of Smith's Moral Philosophy

The Theory of Moral Sentiments has enjoyed a remarkable revival since the late twentieth century, but the revival has been accompanied by sustained criticism, and an honest account must register it. The objections cluster around the device that does the most work in the system – the impartial spectator – and around the sentimentalist foundations it rests on. They are objections of unequal force, and several remain genuinely contested rather than settled.

11.1 The circularity of the impartial spectator

The most searching objection is internal. The impartial spectator is built up out of the sentiments of actual spectators, by abstracting from their partiality; yet it is then asked to *correct* those very sentiments, to stand in judgement against prevailing opinion. Critics, among them Charles Griswold, have pressed the resulting tension: where does the inner spectator acquire the critical distance to overrule the society that formed it? If the impartial spectator is no more than an idealisation of actual social approval, it cannot transcend the biases of the society whose approval it idealises – including the very distortion Smith himself names, the disposition to admire the rich and despise the poor. Smith does gesture, in the face of universal misjudgement, toward an appeal to a higher and more perfectly informed tribunal; but that appeal is left underdeveloped, and to many readers it looks like an admission that genuine impartiality must come from somewhere outside the play of actual sentiment. The dilemma is sharp: either the spectator is wholly socially constituted, and so cannot fully escape social distortion, or it imports a standard from beyond sentiment, and so abandons the sentimentalist programme it was meant to vindicate.

11.2 Conservatism and relativism

A related worry concerns the theory's critical reach. Because moral standards emerge, on Smith's account, from the actual workings of sympathy within a community, the impartial spectator may do little more than internalise and ratify the customs of that community. The theory explains very well why people approve what they in fact approve; it is less clear that it provides leverage for the radical criticism of an entire society's shared sentiments. The natural test case is Smith's own firm condemnation of slavery

and his strictures on rank and hierarchy: commentators ask whether his system actually grounds these judgements, or whether he is relying on independent moral commitments that the spectatorial mechanism cannot by itself supply, since a local impartial spectator in a slaveholding society might be formed to approve what Smith condemns. Defenders reply that the objection underrates the resources of the device. Samuel Fleischacker has argued that Smith's spectator is built precisely to be open to fuller information and to wider perspectives, and Amartya Sen, in adopting the impartial spectator for his own theory of justice, reads it as an *open* and potentially cosmopolitan standpoint – one that invites the views of spectators outside the local group, and so improves on the closed impartiality of social-contract theories. On this defence the spectator is a standing invitation to transcend parochial sentiment rather than a mirror of it. The relativism charge is therefore live but contested, not decisive.

11.3 The partiality and scope of sympathy

Sympathy, as Smith concedes, is unequal: it is strong for those near and like us and weak for the distant and different. As the foundation of an impartial or universal morality this is a structural liability, and critics have doubted that the correction to a “general point of view” is robust enough to repair it. A morality anchored in fellow-feeling may struggle to extend serious moral concern to strangers far away, to future generations, or to non-human animals – precisely the cases in which natural sympathy is faintest and the corrective standpoint most strained. Martha Nussbaum, among others, while crediting the power of Smithian sympathy, has examined the limits of compassion built on imaginative identification and the ways such identification can track salience and similarity rather than need or desert.

11.4 The second-personal objection

A more recent and more technical criticism, associated with Stephen Darwall, targets the *structure* of Smith's account rather than its scope. Smith's spectator is a *third party* who observes conduct and responds with approval or disapproval. But moral obligation, on Darwall's analysis, has an irreducibly *second-personal* form: it is something we owe to one another and can demand of one another, carrying the standing to hold each other accountable. The approval or disapproval of even an idealised observer, the objection runs, does not by itself capture this dimension of authority and accountability that is internal to moral demands – the difference between an act's being *disapproved* and its being a *wrong* that the victim has standing to resent and to claim against. Smith's own grounding of justice in shareable resentment goes some way toward the second-personal, which is why the objection is a refinement of his view as much as a rejection of it; but it identifies something the pure spectator model leaves out.

11.5 Feminist criticism

Feminist readers have questioned the gendered assumptions embedded in Smith's moral psychology. The very architecture of the virtues – the soft, gentle, “amiable” virtues of sensibility set against the great, “awful,” “respectable” virtues of self-command – maps onto a familiar gendering of character, and the propertied, commercial, public subject implicitly presupposed by the spectatorial standpoint leaves little room for the domestic sphere and the relationships of dependence and care that sustain it. The ethics-of-care tradition, in particular, offers a rival sentimentalism that begins not from the impartial spectator's abstraction from particular ties but from the moral weight of those very particular relationships, and from this vantage Smith's elevation of impartiality can look like a displacement of the concrete bonds in which moral life is actually lived.

11.6 Sentiment and normativity: the meta-ethical challenge

The deepest philosophical objection is the one that Smith shares with all sentimentalist ethics, and that the Kantian tradition presses hardest. If moral distinctions are ultimately founded on feeling – on the approbation of a suitably situated spectator – it is unclear that the theory yields genuine *normativity* rather than a sophisticated description of approval. There is a gap between the claim that an impartial spectator *would approve* an action and the claim that the action *is right* or *obligatory*; the first reports a refined sentiment, the second asserts a binding requirement, and the sentimentalist owes an account of how the one becomes the other. From the Kantian standpoint, grounding duty in sentiment and in the general rules that sentiment settles into cannot capture the categorical, rationally necessary character of moral obligation: Smith's “sense of duty” as a regard to general rules looks, to this objection, like ingrained habit and social convention rather than respect for a law that reason gives itself. Whether sentimentalism can answer this – whether the desire for genuine praiseworthiness, as opposed to praise, already builds the needed normativity into the theory – is exactly the question that divides Smith's defenders from his Kantian critics, and it remains open.

11.7 What survives

The cumulative force of these criticisms falls, as with the parallel reckoning over Hegel, on the system's most *ambitious* claim: that a sentiment-based, spectatorial mechanism can by itself ground an impartial, self-correcting, and universally binding morality. What survives the criticism is the wealth of psychological and social insight the mechanism was built to deliver, and on this front *The Theory of Moral Sentiments* stands higher today than at any time since its publication. Its account of moral judgement as imaginative perspective-taking has struck many as a prescient anticipation of modern work on

empathy and the simulation of other minds, and it has drawn renewed attention from economists – Vernon Smith prominent among them – seeking foundations for human sociality that the model of the narrowly self-interested agent omits. Sen and others have rehabilitated the impartial spectator as a working tool of moral and political philosophy. The insight that moral judgement is irreducibly social, that we know ourselves only through the eyes of others, that the desire to be praiseworthy can outrun the desire for praise, and that commercial society systematically corrupts the very sentiments it depends upon – these have proved durable in a way that the foundational claim to self-sufficiency has not. The criticisms, in the end, separate the enduring moral psychology from the over-reaching moral architecture; and the psychology has worn extremely well.

12 Conclusion: The Shape of Smith's Moral Science

The unity beneath *The Theory of Moral Sentiments* is the conviction that morality is neither imposed from above nor read off from solitary reason, but generated from below, in the dense traffic of feeling between people who must live as objects of one another's observation. Sympathy supplies the raw material; the desire for mutual concord sets it in motion; propriety, merit, conscience, and general rules are the successive structures that this motion throws up; and the impartial spectator – first learned from others, then carried within, and finally capable of standing against the crowd – is the regulative ideal that holds the whole together. It is a moral philosophy without a moral sense and without a single master-virtue, in which self-command and justice do the structural work and benevolence supplies the warmth.

Set beside the *Wealth of Nations*, the *Theory of Moral Sentiments* reveals Smith not as a divided author but as a single thinker pursuing one question across two domains: how the uncoordinated actions of many separate individuals, each principally concerned with his own affairs, can nonetheless produce a stable and beneficial order – moral order through sympathy and the impartial spectator, economic order through exchange and the division of labour, both resting on the indispensable pillar of justice. That Smith saw, more sharply than most of his celebrants since, that this same order carries within it the seeds of moral corruption and human diminishment is not a flaw in the unity of his thought but the mark of its honesty. The science of human nature he founded is, in the end, a single edifice with two great wings; and the impartial spectator who presides over the one is never far from the marketplace that fills the other.

13 Suggested Primary Reading

The essential text is *The Theory of Moral Sentiments* (1759; sixth edition, 1790), and the Parts repay reading in order: Part I on sympathy, propriety, and the spectator; Part II on merit, demerit, and justice; Part III on the judgement of our own conduct, conscience, and the impartial spectator, which contains the heart of the book; Part IV on the effects of utility and the deception of nature; Part VI, added in 1790, on prudence, beneficence, and self-command; and Part VII on the systems of moral philosophy. The standard scholarly text is the Glasgow Edition, whose introduction by D. D. Raphael and A. L. Macfie is the authoritative treatment of the relation between Smith's two works and of the *Adam Smith Problem*. For the contrast developed in the final section, the relevant passages of the *Wealth of Nations* (1776) are the account of exchange and self-interest and the division of labour in Book I, the invisible-hand passage in Book IV, and the discussion of the moral and educational effects of the division of labour in Book V. Among modern studies, the works of D. D. Raphael and the intellectual biography by Ian Simpson Ross provide reliable orientation to Smith's life and the architecture of his system.